able to follow the "intense action blocks". It's not a leading part—he's sixth on the cast credits—but the actor says that the Russo siblings have given his character a "beautiful back story" that touches on Avik's impoverished origins. They have taken care to explain why he doesn't budge from his ethics even when on a deadly mission. The mission here involves eliminating the titular character played by Oscar-nominated actor Ryan Gosling.

Dhanush admits being surprised when his co-star broke the ice and cited some of his films. "I don't know if he's seen them or not," Dhanush says, but he cherishes the experience. He adds, "I am always looking to improve myself and to do that one needs to keep seeking knowledge. I observed a lot in every part of filmmaking and I have understood there's a different dimension to do everything."

The Gray Man will have a limited run in US theatres for it is essentially intended for Netflix subscribers. It isn't Dhanush's first dalliance with OTT—Kartik Subbaraj's *Jagame Thandiram* had a direct-to-digital release on Netflix last year, so did his last Hindi release, the romantic drama *Atrangi Re* (2021) which dropped straight on Disney+ Hotstar. Streaming is certainly giving South Asian actors international prominence, with Randeep Hooda (Netflix's *Extraction*), Kubbra Sait (Apple TV's *Foundation*), Alia Bhatt (Netflix's *Heart of Stone*) and Priyanka Chopra (Amazon Prime Video's *Citadel*) all embracing the medium. "It definitely gives great exposure to talents across the world," says Dhanush. "We can all see an evolution happening, and we are a part of it."

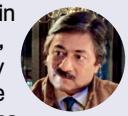
Parts from the West come his way every now and then, but Dhanush acknowledges the "amazing work" happening in India, which keeps him creatively invigorated. His successful association with Tamil filmmaker Vetrimaaran is a case in point. Dhanush feels current film industry trends—S.S. Rajamouli's *RRR*, Sukumar's *Pushpa* and Prashant Neel's *KGF* films become pan-India sensations—only reaffirm what he has been saying since 2013, the year he began promotions for his Hindi debut, *Raanjhana*. "There are no North films and South films. They are all just Indian films," he says. "The audience taste keeps changing and we need to be in harmony with them. I can see we all have started making films for the whole country as one and that is so beautiful." ■

–Suhani Singh

GO WEST!

Indian actors who have made a mark abroad

SAEED JAFFREY (1929-2015)



Born in Malerkotla, Punjab, Jaffrey acted in more than 180 films and TV shows. He played key parts in movies like *My Beautiful Laundrette* (1985) and *Gandhi* (1982).

SHASHI KAPOOR (1938-2017)



The first mainstream Indian actor feted in Hollywood, Kapoor charmed global audiences with moving performances in many Merchant-Ivory productions.

PERSIS KHAMBATTA (1948-1998)



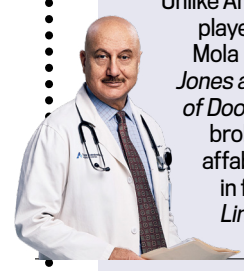
A former Miss India, Khambatta's rise from model to movie star was swift. She is remembered for playing Lieutenant Ilia in *Star Trek: The Motion Picture* (1979).

GULSHAN GROVER (1955–)



His Hollywood films were easy to miss–*Beeper* (2002), *Blind Ambition* (2008) and *Prisoners of the Sun* (2013)–but Grover did keep the Indian flag flying in LA by himself for a while.

ANUPAM KHER (1955–)



Unlike Amrish Puri who played iconic villain Mola Ram in *Indiana Jones and the Temple of Doom* (1984), Kher broke type to play affable characters in films like *Silver Linings Playbook* (2012).

ANIL KAPOOR (1956–)



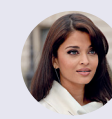
Alongside launching several careers, Danny Boyle's *Slumdog Millionaire* (2008) gave Kapoor's acting trajectory the fillip it needed, and *Mission: Impossible - Ghost Protocol* (2011) soon followed.

IRRFAN KHAN (1967–2020)



Khan never needed a lot of screen time to make an impression. His parts in *Slumdog Millionaire* (2008), *Life of Pi* (2012) and *Inferno* (2016) weren't 'big', but he made them pivotal.

AISHWARYA RAI BACHCHAN (1973–)



Her Hollywood forays have been few, but Bachchan has worked in a Jane Austen adaptation (*Bride and Prejudice*) and starred alongside Steve Martin (*The Pink Panther 2*).

PRIYANKA CHOPRA JONAS (1982–)



The length of her roles is, in no way, a measure of Jonas's success. Not only has she been part of big franchise films–*Baywatch*, *The Matrix*–she is also on every red carpet that Hollywood rolls out.

ALIA BHATT (1993–)



The one Hollywood debut we anxiously await is Alia Bhatt's. She will be soon seen starring alongside Gal Gadot in *Heart of Stone*, a woman-led spy thriller.